

PreACT 8/9 Printable Practice Exam 15

Reading • Exam 04

25 questions • 30 minutes

PART A - QUESTIONS

Passage 1

A Cup That Could Be Held

Elena had promised twelve mugs for the school garden fundraiser, and she wanted them to look like a family. Each one rose in a smooth cylinder from the pottery wheel, with a narrow handle curved like a question mark. Lined together on the studio shelf, they seemed to be asking the same elegant question.

“Who is going to answer them?” asked Mr. Bako, the art teacher.

Elena pointed to the paper sign taped above the shelf: MUGS—TWELVE DOLLARS. “Anyone with twelve dollars.”

Mr. Bako smiled. “Before the kiln, let someone try holding one.”

At lunch, Elena carried an unglazed mug to the library, where Ms. Chen supervised the help desk. Ms. Chen wore a soft brace on her right hand, but Elena had often seen her balance stacks of books against one hip. She slid two fingers toward the mug’s handle, stopped, and tried again with her other hand.

“It’s lovely,” Ms. Chen said. “The opening is a little tight for me.”

Elena felt protective of the row waiting in the studio. A wider handle would interrupt the clean outline she had drawn in her sketchbook. “You could hold the cup around the middle.”

“If it isn’t hot,” Ms. Chen replied. She said it gently, which somehow made Elena hear the problem more clearly.

Back in the studio, Elena attached a thick loop to a practice cup. It looked oversized, like an ear on the wrong animal. She cut it off. On her second attempt, she flattened the outer curve and widened the space inside without adding much weight. The damp clay yielded beneath her thumb, leaving a shallow hollow where a person could rest a finger.

Mr. Bako filled the practice cup with warm water and invited several people to try it. One student held it with four fingers through the loop. Ms. Chen slipped in two fingers and steadied the flattened edge with her thumb. Another teacher, whose hands were large, said the original handle had pinched his knuckles. The new one did not.

Elena expected the wider handle to feel like a compromise she would have to hide. Instead, when she repeated it on the other mugs, the flattened curves created a strong rhythm across the shelf. They no longer looked identical—some thumb hollows were deeper than others—but they still looked related.

On the morning of the fundraiser, Ms. Chen chose a blue mug and lifted it without touching the hot middle. Elena watched the handle carry the weight exactly as she had hoped the narrow ones would.

“It answers the question,” Mr. Bako said.

Elena looked at the remaining mugs. Their handles no longer seemed like question marks. They looked like open doors.

R4-001

Why does Elena initially resist making the mug handles wider?

- A) She believes wider handles will break the pottery wheel.
- B) She has already fired every mug in the kiln.

- C) Mr. Bako has forbidden her to change the original design.
- D) She worries that a wider handle will disrupt the clean appearance she planned.

R4-002

It can reasonably be inferred that Ms. Chen's gentle reply affects Elena because it:

- A) convinces Elena that the fundraiser should be canceled.
- B) makes the practical problem harder for Elena to dismiss as criticism.
- C) reveals that Ms. Chen has never used a mug before.
- D) proves that every customer will want the same color.

R4-003

In the sentence "The damp clay yielded beneath her thumb," the word "yielded" most nearly means:

- A) gave way under pressure.
- B) became completely dry.
- C) changed to a brighter color.
- D) broke away from the mug.

R4-004

What is the main function of the warm-water test in the passage?

- A) It determines which glaze color will sell for the highest price.
- B) It proves that all users hold mugs in exactly the same way.
- C) It provides practical feedback showing that the redesigned handle works for several kinds of hands.
- D) It causes Elena to return permanently to the narrow-handle design.

R4-005

How does Elena's view of the wider handles change?

- A) She first sees them as inexpensive but later decides they cost too much.
- B) She first believes they are stronger but later discovers they cannot hold weight.
- C) She first plans to hide them but later replaces them with narrow metal handles.
- D) She first sees them as awkward compromises but later recognizes both their usefulness and visual rhythm.

R4-006

Which choice best summarizes the passage?

- A) Elena refuses to sell her mugs after discovering that pottery can become hot.
- B) Feedback from several users leads Elena to redesign an elegant but restrictive handle into one that is both useful and visually satisfying.
- C) Mr. Bako makes twelve identical mugs after Elena's first practice cup breaks.
- D) Ms. Chen buys every mug so that the school can replace its pottery wheel.

Passage 2

Passage A: Notes in the Margin

My grandmother's recipe for lentil soup fits on a card crowded with sloping handwriting. Beside the list of ingredients, she wrote "more lemon when it rains." A brown circle marks the place where a wet spoon once rested. None of these details is necessary for cooking the soup, yet each tells me something about the person who cooked it before me.

When families preserve recipes, they should save the original cards and notebooks whenever possible. Handwriting records pace, emphasis, and revision. A crossed-out quantity may show years of adjustment. A comment squeezed into a margin may recall a particular kitchen or season. Even

stains can connect instructions to repeated use.

This does not mean fragile cards should be passed around a crowded cooking class. High-quality scans can protect originals while making them widely available. A typed version may sit beside the image to help readers understand difficult handwriting. But the typed text should not replace the card entirely. A recipe is a set of directions, and sometimes it is also a small record of a life.

Passage B: Recipes People Can Use

At our neighborhood center, volunteers collected recipes from forty households. We received photographs, voice recordings, torn cards, and instructions such as “add flour until it feels right.” If we had simply displayed these materials, many recipes would have remained difficult for new cooks to follow.

We created a tested digital cookbook. Volunteers prepared each dish, measured amounts when the original directions were unclear, and asked contributors to approve the revised wording. Searchable text lets readers find dishes by ingredient. Adjustable serving sizes help a cook prepare food for four people or forty. Audio descriptions make the collection more accessible to readers who cannot use printed pages easily.

Standardizing a recipe can flatten some of its personality, so the digital entries also include scans, recordings, and short notes from contributors. These materials are not obstacles to practical instructions; they provide context for them. Preservation succeeds when a recipe remains connected to its source and becomes usable by someone new. A cookbook should remember where a dish came from, but it should also help the dish reach another table.

R4-007

Which choice best states the central idea of Passage A?

- A) Original recipe cards can preserve personal and historical details that typed instructions alone may not capture.
- B) Stained recipe cards should be used directly in crowded cooking classes.
- C) Every handwritten comment is necessary for preparing a dish correctly.
- D) Digital copies make original family materials impossible to preserve.

R4-008

What is the main purpose of the opening example in Passage A?

- A) To provide complete instructions for making lentil soup.
- B) To argue that recipes should be changed whenever it rains.
- C) To illustrate how handwriting and physical marks can carry meaning beyond the basic directions.
- D) To show that old cards are always easier to read than typed text.

R4-009

According to Passage B, how did volunteers make unclear recipes easier for new cooks to use?

- A) They removed every comment and image from the collection.
- B) They displayed the original materials without adding explanations.
- C) They asked readers to guess all quantities from photographs.
- D) They tested dishes, measured unclear amounts, and obtained contributors' approval for revised wording.

R4-010

As used in Passage B, “flatten” most nearly means:

- A) place on a level table.
- B) reduce the distinctive character of.
- C) make the instructions shorter than one sentence.
- D) convert the recipe into an audio recording.

R4-011

The passages differ mainly in that Passage A emphasizes:

- A) preserving the physical record surrounding a recipe, while Passage B emphasizes making recipes usable and accessible to new cooks.
- B) selling family recipes, while Passage B argues that all recipes should be free.
- C) the nutritional value of soup, while Passage B focuses on serving sizes.
- D) keeping recipes private, while Passage B opposes asking contributors for permission.

R4-012

Which statement would both authors most likely support?

- A) Typed directions should always replace handwritten originals.
- B) Recipes should be preserved only when every quantity is exact.
- C) Practical versions and original source materials can be presented together so readers gain both usability and context.
- D) Scans and recordings prevent new cooks from understanding recipes.

Passage 3**Minutes, Not People**

Students choosing a cafeteria line often count the people waiting and assume the shorter line will be faster. That method can fail when one station serves meals more slowly or when several people near the front have complicated requests. Behavioral researcher Nadi Cole wondered whether displaying estimated minutes instead of the number of people would change how students selected and remained in lines.

Cole's team studied sixteen lunch periods at a secondary school with two serving stations offering the same menu. During half of the lunch periods, a screen above each station displayed the number of people currently in line. During the other half, the screens displayed an estimated wait in minutes. A staff member updated the estimates every two minutes using recent service times. The two display conditions alternated across the four-week study, and the same menus appeared under each condition.

Observers recorded which line each student entered, whether the student switched lines, and how long the student actually waited. The researchers also measured the difference between the average wait at the two stations. After eating, a sample of students completed a brief anonymous survey about how predictable and fair the lines had felt.

When screens showed head counts, 18 percent of students switched lines at least once. When screens showed estimated minutes, 9 percent switched. The minute displays also produced a smaller average gap between the two stations' waiting times, suggesting that students divided themselves more evenly. Actual overall service time did not change because the same workers and equipment served the same number of meals.

The estimates were not always exact. A station could slow suddenly if a tray needed replacement. Even so, surveyed students reported that minute displays made the reason for choosing a line clearer. Several said a line with more people no longer looked automatically worse if its screen showed a shorter wait. A few students preferred head counts because they could verify the number with their own eyes.

Cole cautioned that the study took place in one cafeteria where students already knew the general routine. At an unfamiliar event, people might respond differently. Staff members also knew which display was being tested, although they followed the same serving procedures. Finally, estimates that are frequently inaccurate might lose people's trust.

The study suggests that information can shape a queue even when it does not make service itself faster. A useful display may help people compare what they actually care about—the time required—rather than a visible clue that only partly predicts it.

R4-013

Which choice best states the main idea of the passage?

- A) Cafeteria service becomes faster whenever screens display any kind of information.
- B) Students always choose a line by counting the people in it.
- C) Wait estimates are perfectly accurate when updated every two minutes.
- D) Displaying estimated minutes may help people choose and remain in lines more effectively even without speeding up service.

R4-014

Which result did the researchers observe?

- A) The minute displays doubled the percentage of students who switched lines.
- B) Students switched lines less often when screens showed estimated minutes.
- C) The two stations served different menus throughout the study.
- D) Head-count displays eliminated differences between the stations' waits.

R4-015

Why does the passage mention that a tray replacement could slow a station suddenly?

- A) To illustrate why a wait estimate might not always match the actual wait.
- B) To show that students caused equipment to break by switching lines.
- C) To explain why the cafeteria stopped serving the same menu.
- D) To prove that head counts always predict time correctly.

R4-016

Why did the researchers use the same menus under both display conditions?

- A) To ensure that all meals required exactly the same preparation time.
- B) To prevent students from seeing the screens above the stations.
- C) To reduce the chance that menu preference, rather than display type, explained line choices.
- D) To make staff members unaware of which condition was being tested.

R4-017

Which combination of findings most strongly supports the claim that minute displays helped students distribute themselves more effectively?

- A) The school had two stations, and the study lasted four weeks.
- B) Some students preferred visible head counts, and staff updated estimates every two minutes.
- C) Overall service time stayed the same, and workers used the same equipment.
- D) Line switching decreased, and the gap between the stations' average waiting times became smaller.

R4-018

Which choice best describes the passage's overall structure?

- A) It argues that cafeteria lines should be removed and then describes a new menu.
- B) It introduces a problem with a common clue, describes a comparison study, reports results and reactions, and then discusses limits and implications.
- C) It tells the history of cafeteria screens before ranking several schools.
- D) It presents survey opinions as proof that measured wait times are unnecessary.

Passage 4

Ridges That Guide a Drop

Along a foggy coast, some grasses have narrow leaves marked by tiny lengthwise ridges. Water droplets from fog collect on the leaves even when rain does not fall. Botanist Asha Neri wondered whether the ridges merely increased the leaf surface or also helped guide water toward the plant's base.

To test the idea, Neri's team made seventy-two artificial leaves from the same water-resistant material. One-third were smooth. One-third had shallow grooves running from tip to base, like the ridges on the grass leaves. The remaining leaves had grooves running across their width. All leaves had the same length, width, and total surface area.

The researchers tilted each artificial leaf at thirty degrees in a fog chamber. A small cup beneath the lower end collected water delivered to the base. For forty minutes, cameras recorded where droplets formed, how they joined, and whether they reached the cup. The team then weighed the water left on each leaf and the water collected below it.

All three designs captured similar total amounts of fog. Their ability to deliver that water differed, however. On smooth leaves, droplets often wandered sideways or remained scattered. In the cross-grooved design, many droplets settled into separate grooves and stopped. On lengthwise-grooved leaves, small droplets coalesced into larger drops that followed the grooves downward. Those leaves delivered nearly twice as much water to the cups as the smooth leaves did.

The team repeated the test with leaves tilted at ten degrees. At this gentler angle, water moved more slowly in every design. Lengthwise grooves still delivered the most water, but their advantage was smaller. This result showed that the ridges worked together with gravity rather than moving water entirely on their own.

Finally, the researchers placed short sections of real grass leaves in the chamber. The natural leaves also directed many drops along their ridges, but some drops caught on dust or tiny hairs. The artificial models had helped isolate groove direction, while the real leaves revealed additional features that could alter the path.

Neri's experiment did not measure how much guided fog water living plants absorbed through their roots. Wind could also shake droplets from outdoor leaves before they reached the soil. Field studies are therefore needed to connect water delivery with plant survival. Still, the chamber results support the idea that leaf shape can organize captured water, not merely collect it.

R4-019

Which choice best states the central idea of the passage?

- A) Lengthwise leaf ridges can guide captured fog water downward, although gravity and natural leaf features also affect the result.
- B) Crosswise grooves cause artificial leaves to capture twice as much fog as real leaves.
- C) Smooth leaves cannot capture water unless they are completely vertical.
- D) Coastal grasses obtain all the water they need from fog delivered directly to their roots.

R4-020

Why were all artificial leaves made with the same length, width, and total surface area?

- A) To make the smooth leaves heavier than the grooved leaves.
- B) To ensure that every droplet formed at exactly the same location.
- C) To make groove direction the main planned difference among the three designs.
- D) To reproduce every feature of a living grass leaf.

R4-021

As used in the passage, "coalesced" most nearly means:

- A) evaporated before reaching the cup.
- B) changed from water into ice.
- C) moved upward against gravity.
- D) joined together into larger drops.

R4-022

Which step occurred before the researchers repeated the test at a ten-degree angle?

- A) They measured how much fog water living plants absorbed through their roots.
- B) They tested the three artificial designs at thirty degrees and measured water on and below them.
- C) They exposed the artificial leaves to outdoor wind for an entire season.
- D) They removed every groove from the real grass leaves.

R4-023

What can reasonably be inferred from the similar total fog capture among the three artificial designs?

- A) The main advantage of lengthwise grooves in this experiment involved directing water rather than capturing more of it.
- B) Groove direction had no effect on any part of water movement.
- C) Crosswise grooves delivered more water because they captured less.
- D) Only smooth leaves allowed droplets to form in the chamber.

R4-024

What is the main function of the paragraph about real grass leaves?

- A) To prove that artificial models are always more accurate than living plants.
- B) To show that dust and hairs prevent every natural droplet from moving.
- C) To compare the simplified model with natural leaves and identify additional features that influence water paths.
- D) To introduce a grass species that has no ridges.

R4-025

Which choice best summarizes the experiment's findings?

- A) Lengthwise grooves directed more captured water toward the base than smooth or cross-grooved surfaces, but angle and natural leaf features affected movement.
- B) Artificial leaves with crosswise grooves captured no fog and remained completely dry.
- C) The chamber experiment proved that guided fog water always increases plant survival outdoors.
- D) Smooth leaves delivered the most water because droplets could wander sideways.

PART B - ANSWER KEY + EXPLANATIONS

R4-001 - Correct: D) She worries that a wider handle will disrupt the clean appearance she planned.

Explanation: Elena thinks a wider handle will interrupt the clean outline in her sketchbook and feels protective of the matching row of mugs.

R4-002 - Correct: B) makes the practical problem harder for Elena to dismiss as criticism.

Explanation: After Ms. Chen calmly points out that holding the hot middle is not practical, Elena hears the problem more clearly and returns to the studio to redesign the handle.

R4-003 - Correct: A) gave way under pressure.

Explanation: Elena presses a shallow thumb hollow into the damp clay, so the clay yields by giving way and changing shape under her thumb.

R4-004 - Correct: C) It provides practical feedback showing that the redesigned handle works for several kinds of hands.

Explanation: Different testers use the wider handle successfully, and a teacher confirms that it does not pinch his knuckles. The test evaluates the handle in realistic use.

R4-005 - Correct: D) She first sees them as awkward compromises but later recognizes both their usefulness and visual rhythm.

Explanation: Elena's first wide loop looks oversized, and she expects the final version to feel like a compromise. Repeated across the mugs, however, the curves look related and function well.

R4-006 - Correct: B) Feedback from several users leads Elena to redesign an elegant but restrictive handle into one that is both useful and visually satisfying.

Explanation: Elena tests and revises the narrow handle after Ms. Chen's feedback, then discovers that the more usable design also creates a pleasing family of mugs.

R4-007 - Correct: A) Original recipe cards can preserve personal and historical details that typed instructions alone may not capture.

Explanation: Passage A describes handwriting, revisions, marginal notes, and stains as records of a person and repeated use that should remain available alongside typed text.

R4-008 - Correct: C) To illustrate how handwriting and physical marks can carry meaning beyond the basic directions.

Explanation: The rainy-day note and spoon stain are not required to cook the soup, but they reveal something about the grandmother and the recipe's use.

R4-009 - Correct: D) They tested dishes, measured unclear amounts, and obtained contributors' approval for revised wording.

Explanation: Passage B explicitly states that volunteers prepared the dishes, supplied measurements where needed, and asked contributors to approve the wording.

R4-010 - Correct: B) reduce the distinctive character of.

Explanation: Passage B acknowledges that standard wording may remove some of a recipe's personality, so "flatten" means reduce its distinctive character.

R4-011 - Correct: A) preserving the physical record surrounding a recipe, while Passage B emphasizes making recipes usable and accessible to new cooks.

Explanation: Passage A focuses on handwriting, marks, and original cards. Passage B focuses on testing, searching, resizing, and audio access while still retaining source materials.

R4-012 - Correct: C) Practical versions and original source materials can be presented together so readers gain both usability and context.

Explanation: Passage A recommends scans with typed text, and Passage B combines standardized entries with scans, recordings, and contributor notes.

R4-013 - Correct: D) Displaying estimated minutes may help people choose and remain in lines more effectively even without speeding up service.

Explanation: Minute displays were associated with fewer switches and a smaller wait-time gap, while the passage clearly states that overall service speed did not change.

R4-014 - Correct: B) Students switched lines less often when screens showed estimated minutes.

Explanation: Eighteen percent of students switched under the head-count condition, compared with 9 percent under the estimated-minute condition.

R4-015 - Correct: A) To illustrate why a wait estimate might not always match the actual wait.

Explanation: A sudden slowdown is an example of an event that the displayed estimate may not immediately reflect, explaining why estimates were sometimes inexact.

R4-016 - Correct: C) To reduce the chance that menu preference, rather than display type, explained line choices.

Explanation: Repeating the same menus under both conditions helps keep menu appeal from becoming a systematic difference between head-count and minute-display days.

R4-017 - Correct: D) Line switching decreased, and the gap between the stations' average waiting times became smaller.

Explanation: Less switching indicates more stable choices, while the smaller difference in waits directly suggests that students were more evenly divided between stations.

R4-018 - Correct: B) It introduces a problem with a common clue, describes a comparison study, reports results and reactions, and then discusses limits and implications.

Explanation: The passage begins with the weakness of head counts, explains the two display conditions, reports behavioral and survey findings, and closes with cautions and a broader conclusion.

R4-019 - Correct: A) Lengthwise leaf ridges can guide captured fog water downward, although gravity and natural leaf features also affect the result.

Explanation: The designs captured similar amounts, but lengthwise grooves delivered more water; the angle test and real leaves showed that gravity, dust, and hairs also mattered.

R4-020 - Correct: C) To make groove direction the main planned difference among the three designs.

Explanation: Keeping size, area, and material constant reduces alternative explanations, allowing the researchers to compare smooth, lengthwise-grooved, and cross-grooved surfaces.

R4-021 - Correct: D) joined together into larger drops.

Explanation: The passage says small droplets coalesced into larger drops before following the grooves downward, so the word means joined together.

R4-022 - Correct: B) They tested the three artificial designs at thirty degrees and measured water on and below them.

Explanation: The first chamber test tilted the artificial leaves at thirty degrees and measured retained and delivered water; the ten-degree test came afterward.

R4-023 - Correct: A) The main advantage of lengthwise grooves in this experiment involved directing water rather than capturing more of it.

Explanation: All designs captured similar totals, but lengthwise grooves delivered nearly twice as much as smooth leaves, so their advantage was organization and transport rather than added capture.

R4-024 - Correct: C) To compare the simplified model with natural leaves and identify additional features that influence water paths.

Explanation: The natural leaves also guide water along ridges, but dust and hairs alter some paths. This shows both the model's value and what it leaves out.

R4-025 - Correct: A) Lengthwise grooves directed more captured water toward the base than smooth or cross-grooved surfaces, but angle and natural leaf features affected movement.

Explanation: Lengthwise grooves produced the greatest delivery, their advantage decreased at a gentler angle, and real-leaf dust and hairs sometimes interrupted the route.